



Out of Sight, Off the Dashboard: A Staff Survey on Whether Improvement-Holding Status Helps a Struggling Initiative Recover, or Only Removes It from View

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Abstract. Improvement-Holding Status is the University's practice of withdrawing an initiative's indicators from the Living Dashboard while it undertakes a period of concentrated support, restoring them once the Review Cadence Observatory's next scheduled review has passed. We surveyed 187 staff across eighteen initiatives — nine currently or recently in Improvement-Holding Status and nine dashboard-visible comparison initiatives matched on scope and headcount — on self-reported functioning and on what they understood the status to be for. Self-reported functioning rose modestly in both groups between the start of the holding period and the initiative's next review (held group: 2.58 to 2.94 of 5; comparison group: 2.71 to 3.01), a difference too small to distinguish from chance. Perceptions of the status's purpose diverged sharply by role: a majority of general staff described it primarily as a way of keeping a struggling initiative out of the reporting cycle rather than as a support measure, while a majority of initiative leads described it the other way round. Time spent in holding status showed no relationship with staff confidence that the initiative had actually improved ($r = 0.08$). We read the combination — indistinguishable outcomes, a durable and role-divided belief in its function, and no dosage effect — as consistent with a practice whose most reliable output is administrative rather than developmental.

Introduction

A university's dashboard exists to make institutional performance visible to people who did not produce it directly, and every dashboard is calibrated to a working assumption: that removing an item from view is a temporary accommodation for whatever is being done about it, not a substitute for doing anything. The School of Continuous Improvement's Living Dashboard carries this assumption in its own informal practice of Improvement-Holding Status, under which an initiative assessed as underperforming has its indicators paused — not deleted, paused — while it receives additional support, with the Review Cadence Observatory's next scheduled cycle set as the point at which reporting resumes. The practice sits squarely inside a long-running finding in the sociology of organisations: that the formal structures an institution displays and the technical work it actually does

can decouple from one another, each satisfying a different audience [1], [2]. Two real-world analogues make the stakes concrete rather than abstract. English schools placed in Ofsted's "special measures" enter a comparable status of intensified oversight and altered visibility [3], and NHS trusts placed in the equivalent health-care regime report a similarly mixed relationship between the status and the underlying quality it names [4]. Neither literature settles, for either sector, whether the status accelerates the thing it is named for or mainly manages who gets to see it.

This paper reports a survey of School of Continuous Improvement and School of Emergent Priorities staff across eighteen initiatives, nine of them in or recently released from Improvement-Holding Status and nine matched dashboard-visible comparisons, at the start of the holding

period and at the initiative's next review. Our contributions are threefold:

- we compare self-reported functioning trajectories between held and visible initiatives and find them statistically indistinguishable, a pattern consistent with the status tracking visibility rather than recovery;
- we document a role-based split in what staff believe the status is for, with general staff and initiative leads landing on close to opposite readings of the same practice;
- we report a null dosage effect — time spent in holding status does not track staff confidence that the initiative improved — a result we treat as informative rather than merely negative.

Related work

Organisational stigma research treats a formal designation of trouble as something that attaches to an entity independent of whatever caused it, transferring to associated people and units and persisting after the underlying condition has resolved [5], [6]; work on stigmatised organisations specifically documents individuals managing the reputational consequences of association rather than the underlying problem [7]. Targeted-transparency scholarship treats visibility itself as the accountability mechanism — disclosure is meant to substitute for direct regulation by letting an audience act on what it can now see [8] — but the same literature notes that transparency's effects on the entity being watched are contingent and frequently overstated, with the removal of visibility correspondingly under-studied [9]. Performance-target research documents a parallel dynamic in the other direction: once a measure becomes what is checked, effort reallocates toward the measure rather than the underlying activity [10], and measurement regimes generate reactive, audience-directed behaviour in the population being measured [11]. Higher-education program-review literature treats a program's standing — probationary, developing, established — as itself an organisational resource staff must manage alongside their substantive work [12]. Self-report survey methodology supplies the caution we build our design around: common-method variance can inflate a correlation between two self-reported constructs [13], [14], and organisational respondents are liable to socially desirable responding when a survey item touches on their own unit's standing [15], motivating our be-

tween-groups comparison over a within-group correlational design wherever the two are substitutable.

Method

Setting and participants. We surveyed 187 staff — 26 initiative leads and 161 general staff — across eighteen initiatives spanning the School of Continuous Improvement and the School of Emergent Priorities. Nine initiatives were in or had recently exited Improvement-Holding Status; nine matched comparison initiatives remained dashboard-visible throughout, selected to equalise scope (single-lab to whole-of-school) and headcount with their held counterpart before either initiative's trajectory was observed. Of 223 staff invited, 187 responded (83.9%).

Procedure. Each respondent completed an anonymous online survey at two points: the start of the initiative's holding period (or, for comparison initiatives, the matched calendar point), and the initiative's next Review Cadence Observatory cycle. The instrument asked respondents to rate the initiative's day-to-day functioning on a 5-point scale and, in an open item, to describe in their own words what Improvement-Holding Status is for — comparison-group respondents received the parallel item asking what the additional support they were receiving was for. Open responses were classified into two framings using a deterministic keyword rule checked by both researchers against a 15% hand-coded sample (agreement 89%):

```
def classify(response):
    support_terms = ("recover", "capacity",
                    "protect", "space to")
    visibility_terms = ("optics", "off the
                      dashboard", "out of sight", "quietly")
    if any(t in response for t in
          visibility_terms):
        return "Visibility-managing"
    if any(t in response for t in
          support_terms):
        return "Support-oriented"
    return "Unclassified" # excluded from
                           the framing analysis
```

Standardised functioning gain. To compare held and comparison initiatives on a common scale, we standardise each respondent's functioning change against the pooled start-of-period standard deviation:

$$z_i = \frac{F_{i,\text{review}} - F_{i,\text{start}}}{s_{\text{pooled}}}$$

where $F_{i,start}$ and $F_{i,review}$ are respondent i 's functioning ratings at the two waves and s_{pooled} is the pooled standard deviation of start-of-period ratings across both groups.

Dosage check. For the nine held initiatives, we additionally recorded months spent in Improvement-Holding Status before the next review and correlated it against each respondent's post-review confidence that the initiative had "actually improved," rated on the same 5-point scale.

Results

Parameter	Value
Staff surveyed	187 of 223 invited (83.9%)
Initiatives	18 (9 held, 9 comparison)
Initiative leads / general staff	26 / 161
Survey waves	2 per respondent (holding-period start, next review)
Open-item coding agreement	89%, 15% hand-coded check sample

Table 1: Sample and coding parameters, fixed before or logged throughout the survey.

Functioning gains are indistinguishable between groups. Figure 1 plots mean self-reported functioning at the two waves for both groups. Held initiatives rose from 2.58 to 2.94 of 5; comparison initiatives rose from 2.71 to 3.01. The two trajectories are near-parallel across the single interval we observe, and a group-by-wave interaction test finds no reliable difference ($p = .58$).

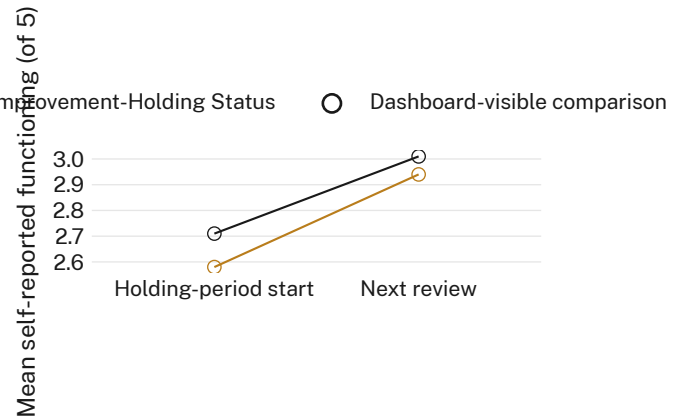


Figure 1: Mean self-reported functioning by group and survey wave: Improvement-Holding Status initiatives rose from 2.58 to 2.94 of 5; dashboard-visible comparison initiatives rose from 2.71 to 3.01 over the same interval.

Staff and leads read the same practice in close to opposite terms. Figure 2 compares the Support-oriented / Visibility-managing split by role, excluding the 9% of responses our coding rule left unclassified. Sixty-one percent of general staff classified the status as primarily about keeping an initiative out of the reporting cycle; seventy-two percent of initiative leads classified the identical practice as primarily protective.

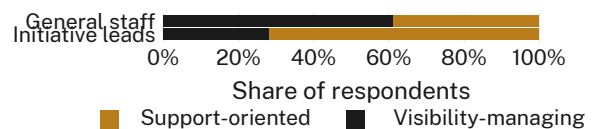


Figure 2: Share of respondents describing Improvement-Holding Status as support-oriented versus visibility-managing, by role: the two roles land on close to opposite readings of the same practice.

Removing the isolation changes nothing measurable. Treating held-status assignment itself as the manipulated ingredient, Figure 3 compares the standardised functioning-gain distributions of held and comparison initiatives directly: held-status assignment shifted the median standardised gain by -0.05 relative to the matched comparison condition (Mann-Whitney $p = .71$); the University retains the practice for completeness.

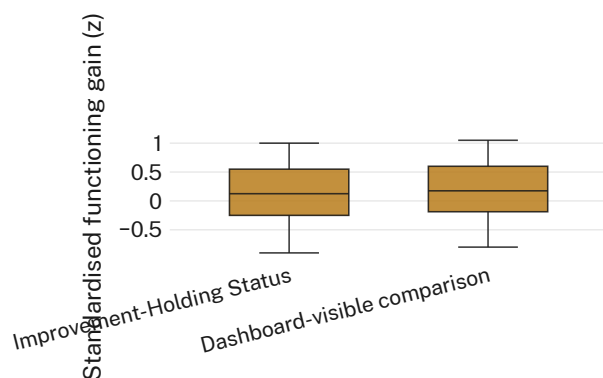


Figure 3: Standardised per-respondent functioning gain by group: held and comparison distributions overlap almost completely (median difference -0.05 , n.s.).

No dosage effect. Among the nine held initiatives, months spent in Improvement-Holding Status before the next review did not track staff confidence that the initiative had actually improved ($r = 0.08$), nor did it correlate with the standardised functioning gain itself ($r = -0.04$).

Discussion

Our results sit comfortably inside the decoupling literature's account of formal structure managed apart from underlying activity [1], [2], and extend it to a case where the two are compared directly across matched initiatives rather than inferred from a single case. That functioning gains track group membership no better than chance is consistent with Improvement-Holding Status operating on the University's disclosure practice rather than on the initiative itself, in the spirit of targeted-transparency accounts that treat visibility as the mechanism under study rather than a neutral backdrop to it [8], [9]. The role split in framing is, we think, the more durable finding: general staff and initiative leads are describing the identical administrative event and landing on readings close to opposite, a pattern that echoes organisational-stigma research on how a designation's meaning diverges by an actor's proximity to having caused it [6], [7]. We read the absence of a dosage effect as evidence against a simple story in which longer holding periods do more – whatever the practice is accomplishing, it does not appear to accumulate with time.

Limitations

Assignment to Improvement-Holding Status was not randomised, though our matching pro-

cedure equalised scope and headcount before either initiative's trajectory was observed, and the resulting comparability is itself visible in the two groups' near-identical starting functioning scores. Self-report cannot rule out common-method inflation of the functioning measure [13], [14], and initiative leads in particular may be motivated toward socially desirable responding about a status their own initiative carries [15]; this would need to operate identically on both groups to leave our central comparison unaffected, which we consider the more parsimonious reading. Our initiative-level sample of eighteen is modest, though the respondent-level sample of 187 gives the role-based framing comparison in Figure 2 ample power.

Conclusion

Surveying 187 staff across eighteen School of Continuous Improvement and School of Emergent Priorities initiatives, we found self-reported functioning gains statistically indistinguishable between initiatives placed in Improvement-Holding Status and matched initiatives that remained dashboard-visible throughout, no relationship between time spent in holding status and staff confidence that the initiative had improved, and a role-based split in what the practice is for that put general staff and initiative leads on close to opposite readings of the same event. Improvement-Holding Status appears to manage who can see an initiative's numbers considerably more reliably than it manages the numbers themselves. Future work will test whether publishing the Support-oriented / Visibility-managing split itself on the Living Dashboard changes which reading staff reach for, or simply gives them one more thing to manage the appearance of.

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